

OMNI: BLACK MERIDIAN

Document type: Active Project Brief / Game Design and Production Brief

Working title: OMNI : BLACK MERIDIAN

Title status: Provisional; trademark availability unverified

Complexity: HIGH

Platform: Windows PC / Steam

Genre: Single-player real-time-with-pause mafia empire management strategy

Target price: USD \$29.99

Engine decision: Godot 4.7

Production route: HYBRID

Vertical-slice target: 45–60 minutes

Full-game target: 12–15 hours for a first campaign

Commercial positioning: Premium strategy game with cinematic, high-density presentation rather than a simulation sandbox

1. Executive Product Decision

The game should not attempt to simulate a complete city, individual citizen schedules, tactical combat, or unrestricted first-person exploration.

It should simulate:

1. district ownership and influence;
2. economic networks;
3. character relationships;
4. police and institutional pressure;
5. rival strategic intent;
6. state-generated crises;
7. narrative consequences.

The city then **visualizes those systems convincingly** through traffic, crowds, patrols, signage, weather, lighting, racket activity and district deterioration.

This separation is the central production decision:

The strategic simulation is authoritative. The city population is a visual proxy.

The player must believe the city is alive without the studio actually building a city-scale life simulation.

The cinematic first-person environments follow the same rule. They are small, highly controlled spaces used to make consequences emotionally tangible. They are not a second open-world game.

2. Original-IP and Rights Boundary

The protected creative expression of another series must not enter production. Only abstract genre structures are retained:

- ruling criminal dynasty;
- competing factions;
- trusted fixer;
- disputed territory;
- secrets and betrayal;
- institutional pressure;
- escalating retaliation.

Copyright generally protects specific expression rather than abstract ideas, systems or methods, and commonplace genre elements may fall outside protection. Specific characters, dialogue, visual designs, scenes and distinctive combinations can still be protected.

Therefore:

- Do not reproduce MobLand character names, biographies, relationships or dialogue patterns.
- Do not reproduce individual plot beats or episode structures.
- Do not use London geography, recognizable estates, costumes or production design.
- Do not market the game as an adaptation, unofficial game or direct MobLand analogue.
- Do not use MobLand imagery in public-facing mood boards, store assets or trailers.
- Keep the comparison table in internal documentation only.
- Conduct a trademark search before approving the final title; confusing similarity in name and related entertainment goods can create trademark problems even where the underlying concept is original.

This strategy materially reduces rights exposure but cannot guarantee “zero risk.” Final title, character bible and first public trailer should receive an IP review before announcement.

3. Original Premise

Setting

Black Meridian is a rain-soaked interspecies metropolis built around a vertical transit nexus connecting human, alien and sapient-creature territories.

The city was officially unified by the **Meridian Accord**, but the Accord merely legitimized the dynasties that already controlled freight, security, nightlife, synthetic identities, medical contraband and political access.

A fragile ruling compact is destabilized when a protected courier is found dead inside neutral territory carrying evidence that could collapse all six dynasties.

The player controls **Aiko Velora**, the ruling compact’s principal resolver: negotiator, investigator, cleaner, strategist and, when required, executioner.

Player fantasy

"I do not command armies. I decide which problem becomes somebody else's war."

Aiko is not a traditional action hero. Her power comes from information, preparation, leverage and knowing which person can safely be sacrificed.

4. Character and Faction Map

Names other than Aiko Velora are role placeholders until canonical names and visual masters are approved.

OMNI character	Strategic role	Narrative function	Gameplay specialization
Aiko Velora	Playable fixer / Resolver	Human emotional anchor and player avatar	Can personally intervene in critical jobs; improves information quality and reduces collateral damage
Nordic-Alien	Regent of the ruling Meridian Compact	Aging authority holding incompatible factions together	Political protection, intimidation, access to elite institutions
Lyrian Humanoid	Heir and diplomatic lieutenant	Reformist successor whose loyalty is uncertain	Negotiation, legitimate fronts, political influence
Bengal-Felid	Operations lieutenant and territorial enforcer	Loyal but increasingly resentful field commander	Security, retaliation, district defence, physical extraction
Grey-Alien	Intelligence lieutenant	Emotionally unreadable data broker with hidden objectives	Surveillance, evidence alteration, counterintelligence
Raven-Woman	Boss of the Corvine Assembly	Primary rival dynasty leader	Blackmail, social infiltration, betrayal and disinformation
Peregrine-Avian	Leader of the Skyline Combine	Neutral logistics power that can become ally or second rival	Smuggling, rapid transport, interdiction and market manipulation

Vertical-slice roster

Only four hero-grade characters are required:

- Aiko Velora;
- Nordic-Alien Regent;
- Bengal-Felid lieutenant;

- Raven-Woman rival boss.

The Lyrian, Grey and Peregrine characters may appear as portraits or narrative references, but should not receive full production models during the first six months.

5. Core Loop

5.1 Thirty-second loop

Every 20–40 seconds, the player performs the following sequence:

1. Detect a change

2. police patrol enters a district;
3. racket income drops;
4. rival influence increases;
5. lieutenant requests action;
6. an evidence chain progresses;
7. a fixer crisis appears.

8. Inspect context

9. district overlay;
10. involved characters;
11. current heat;
12. expected profit;
13. loyalty risk;
14. known and unknown consequences.

15. Make one commitment

16. assign an operative;
17. fund an operation;
18. choose an approach;
19. delay the problem;
20. personally intervene as Aiko;
21. sacrifice another objective.

22. Watch the city react

23. vehicles leave the headquarters;
24. operatives move through the district;

- 25. police reroute;
- 26. rival agents respond;
- 27. the target venue changes state.

28. **Absorb the consequence**

- 29. cash, control, evidence, injury, loyalty or narrative state changes;
- 30. a new problem is created rather than every problem simply disappearing.

The game runs in real time with pause and three speed settings. It is not turn-based, but decisions are discrete and readable.

5.2 Thirty-minute loop

One complete **Night Cycle** lasts approximately 25–35 minutes.

Phase 1 — Council: 3–5 minutes

- review the previous night;
- select a strategic priority;
- inspect family relationships;
- allocate clean cash;
- assign lieutenants;
- choose one district objective.

Phase 2 — Operations: 15–20 minutes

- run four to six rackets or fixer jobs;
- react to rival moves;
- manage heat and evidence;
- secure, lose or destabilize venues;
- decide whether Aiko personally intervenes.

Phase 3 — Crisis: 5–8 minutes

- a state-driven crisis forces a high-cost decision;
- possible transition to a cinematic splat environment;
- one relationship changes materially;
- the city enters a new strategic state.

Phase 4 — Reckoning: 2–3 minutes

- income and laundering resolve;
- institutional pressure advances;
- loyalty changes become visible;
- rival intentions update;
- the next Night Cycle is previewed.

A player should be able to stop after one Night Cycle and feel that a complete dramatic episode occurred.

6. Design Pillars

Pillar 1 — Fixer Strategy, Not Tactical Combat

Most mafia games make the player a general, shooter or city painter. Black Meridian makes the player a **problem architect**.

Every significant operation asks:

- What is the actual problem?
- Who needs to believe what?
- What evidence must disappear?
- Who gains leverage?
- Which consequence can be tolerated?

There is no tactical combat layer. Violence exists, but it is an operational approach with political, economic and emotional consequences.

This cuts an entire game's worth of animation, AI, level design and balancing while strengthening the fixer identity.

Pillar 2 — The City Shows the State

District statistics are not confined to menus.

When the player changes a district:

- legitimate traffic increases or disappears;
- police presence changes;
- neon signage and business activity change;
- rival colors and markings appear;
- crowds avoid or occupy streets;
- specific venue types open or close;
- rainwater reflects faction-controlled signs;
- convoys and patrols reveal current operations.

The city is a strategic dashboard rendered as a premium diorama.

Pillar 3 — Loyalty Is a Network of Motives

Characters do not possess a single loyalty number.

Each important character has:

- public trust;
- private ambition;
- fear;
- grievance;

- ideological alignment;
- debts;
- secrets;
- relationship edges to other characters.

A lieutenant can remain loyal to Aiko while betraying the Regent. Another may betray the dynasty to protect a sibling. Betrayal is deterministic and telegraphed rather than random.

Pillar 4 — Walk Through the Consequence

Major decisions occasionally leave the management layer and enter a constrained first-person environment.

The player does not enter these scenes to shoot enemies. The player enters to:

- inspect evidence;
- choose where to stand during a confrontation;
- privately speak to one character before another arrives;
- plant, remove or reinterpret an object;
- decide what information Aiko reveals;
- physically walk away from someone who has been condemned.

These scenes provide production-value spikes without becoming a full first-person game.

7. Strategic Systems

7.1 District and Territory Map

The full city contains five districts. Each district contains six to ten strategic venues connected through roads and influence edges.

A district is not simply owned or unowned. It tracks:

- **Influence:** social and political control;
- **Security:** ability to defend operations;
- **Prosperity:** economic potential;
- **Fear:** willingness of locals to cooperate;
- **Visibility:** how exposed criminal activity is;
- **Institutional presence:** police, inspectors and civic agencies;
- **Faction pressure:** influence exerted by each dynasty.

Venue types

- racket;
- legitimate front;
- safehouse;
- transit node;
- political office;
- intelligence node;

- neutral institution;
- story location.

Control states

1. Unknown
2. Contested
3. Influenced
4. Controlled
5. Fortified
6. Compromised

“Compromised” is distinct from “lost.” The player may still own a venue that has been infiltrated or tied to an evidence case.

Simulation architecture

The authoritative simulation runs on district and venue data.

Traffic, pedestrians and visible operatives are spawned from that data but do not independently determine it.

A vehicle reaching a building is visual feedback. The operation result comes from the strategic simulation, not vehicle physics.

7.2 Economy

The economy has two currencies:

- **Dirty cash:** immediately available for criminal activity but creates exposure;
- **Clean capital:** slower to produce, required for upgrades, political influence and legitimate acquisitions.

Rackets

Initial racket categories:

- contraband logistics;
- protection;
- illegal medical clinic;
- identity fabrication;
- underground gaming;
- information brokerage.

Fronts

Initial legitimate fronts:

- nightclub;
- freight company;

- private security firm;
- luxury clinic;
- property holding company;
- media and event company.

Core calculations

```
DirtyIncome =
  BaseYield
  × DistrictDemand
  × OperationalStaff
  × ControlModifier
  × DisruptionModifier
```

```
CleanCapital =
  min(AvailableDirtyCash, LaunderingCapacity)
  × FrontEfficiency
  × (1 - OperatingCost)
```

```
ExposureGain =
  UnlaunderedOverflow
  × RacketRisk
  × DistrictVisibility
  + EvidenceFromFailedJobs
```

Economic tension

The player should usually have more dirty cash than can safely be laundered.

The choice is therefore not merely “earn more.” It is:

- slow expansion;
- tolerate exposure;
- buy another front;
- pressure an existing front;
- bribe an official;
- temporarily stop a profitable racket;
- allow a rival to operate and tax them.

7.3 Heat, Evidence and Institutional Pressure

A single wanted-level meter is too shallow.

Use three related systems:

Local Heat

Per-district police attention caused by visible incidents and persistent criminal activity.

Effects:

- additional patrols;
- lower customer traffic;
- disrupted operations;
- inspections;
- higher job difficulty.

Evidence Chains

Named investigations connecting people, vehicles, venues and incidents.

Example:

```
Dock Shooting
├─ getaway vehicle
├─ witness
├─ weapon supplier
└─ compromised security footage
```

The player can remove one link, redirect the chain, discredit a witness or frame another faction. Merely paying money should rarely delete an entire case.

Central Pressure

Campaign-wide scrutiny from the **Civic Integrity Directorate**.

Pressure thresholds trigger:

- asset freezes;
- coordinated raids;
- informant attempts;
- political defections;
- special investigators;
- endgame conditions.

Pressure should rise slowly enough for the player to understand causality.

7.4 Rival-Family AI

Use utility AI, not a general-purpose machine-learning agent or expensive planner.

Every strategic tick, a rival evaluates a limited set of actions:

- expand;
- probe;
- sabotage;
- recruit;
- bribe;
- retaliate;
- negotiate;
- frame;
- reduce heat;
- defend;
- exploit a character grievance.

Each action receives a score based on:

- faction objectives;
- available resources;
- known player weakness;
- emotional memory;
- current heat;
- expected retaliation;
- leader personality;
- confidence in intelligence.

The rival then chooses one high-value action with controlled noise.

Fairness rule

Rivals operate from imperfect information. Higher difficulty improves:

- planning horizon;
- risk evaluation;
- use of indirect actions;
- coordination between operations.

Higher difficulty should not simply provide invisible income multipliers.

Rival memory

The AI records:

- promises kept;
- humiliations;
- disproportionate retaliation;
- spared characters;
- accepted deals;
- territories repeatedly contested.

This memory alters future action scores and dialogue.

7.5 Fixer Job System

Fixer jobs are generated from the current simulation state. They are not disconnected side missions.

Job origins

- failed racket;
- compromised operative;
- intercepted shipment;
- disloyal lieutenant;
- witness;
- missing payment;
- rival provocation;
- police investigation;
- political request;
- family scandal.

Four-stage structure

1. Intake

The player sees:

- apparent problem;
- involved people;
- deadline;
- known evidence;
- visible stakes.

Some information is intentionally missing.

2. Preparation

Choose up to three preparatory actions:

- surveillance;
- acquire leverage;
- bribe access;
- plant an operative;
- obtain a clean vehicle;
- alter records;
- pressure an associate;
- prepare a false explanation.

3. Intervention

Choose an approach:

- negotiate;
- extract;
- intimidate;

- bribe;
- sabotage;
- frame;
- expose;
- eliminate;
- sacrifice;
- personally intervene as Aiko.

4. Cover-up

Choose how the city interprets the outcome:

- accident;
- rival attack;
- official operation;
- internal disappearance;
- public warning;
- unresolved mystery.

Job duration

- minor systemic job: 60–90 seconds;
- major job: 2–4 minutes;
- story job with cinematic transition: 5–10 minutes.

Resolution

Results should not be a binary success/failure.

Possible result dimensions:

- objective achieved;
- evidence generated;
- collateral damage;
- operative injury;
- rival suspicion;
- public fear;
- relationship change;
- new leverage;
- delayed consequence.

7.6 Loyalty and Betrayal

Public information

The player can see:

- current trust;
- recent grievances;
- known relationships;

- stated ambition;
- current responsibilities.

Hidden information

The player must infer:

- concealed secret;
- true ideological loyalty;
- willingness to kill another character;
- external leverage;
- private succession plan.

Betrayal calculation

```
BetrayalPressure =
  Ambition
  + AccumulatedGrievance
  + RivalLeverage
  + SurvivalPressure
  + Opportunity
  - Trust
  - SharedSuccess
  - FearOfConsequences
```

Betrayal requires both:

1. pressure above the character's threshold;
2. a viable opportunity.

This makes betrayal preventable. The player may notice:

- delayed responses;
- unexplained absence;
- operational mistakes;
- private meetings;
- unusual requests;
- conflict between two lieutenants.

A betrayal should never be resolved by an untelegraphed random roll.

7.7 Cinematic Splat Sequences

Trigger conditions

A splat sequence activates only when:

- a chapter threshold is reached;
- Aiko personally intervenes in a major fixer job;

- a loyalty state crosses a permanent boundary;
- a boss confrontation occurs;
- a critical evidence scene becomes available.

The full game should contain approximately 10–12 splat sequences. The vertical slice contains one.

Sequence types

1. **Crime-scene inspection**
2. **Walk-and-talk negotiation**
3. **Private confrontation**
4. **Dynasty council**
5. **Aftermath or execution decision**

Interaction model

- first-person movement;
- no jumping;
- no combat;
- constrained walkable area;
- three to six interaction points;
- one to three characters;
- five to eight minutes;
- dialogue choices tied directly to strategy state;
- management simulation paused while inside.

Hybrid scene composition

The environment is a Gaussian splat.

The following remain conventional 3D:

- characters;
- doors that must move;
- handheld objects;
- evidence items;
- interaction markers;
- collision;
- navigation boundaries.

A static splat should never be expected to supply interactive geometry, dynamic characters or reliable physics.

8. MobLand Structure → Original OMNI Structure

This is an internal abstraction map, not public positioning.

Source structural role	Original OMNI equivalent	Material transformation
London organized-crime setting	Black Meridian, an interspecies vertical transit metropolis	New geography, architecture, economy, species and political history
Established ruling family	Meridian Compact	Multi-species governing criminal alliance rather than a conventional human family
Aging patriarch or central ruler	Nordic-Alien Regent	Non-human Accord-era political survivor
Family fixer	Aiko Velora, the Resolver	Human strategic operator who uses information and intervention rather than acting as a conventional mob enforcer
Heir and succession conflict	Lyrian Humanoid diplomat	Reformist successor divided between legitimacy and dynasty survival
Loyal enforcer	Bengal-Felid operations lieutenant	Territorial commander with loyalty, pride and succession grievances
Family intelligence network	Grey-Alien intelligence lieutenant	Synthetic identity, surveillance and memory-market specialist
Rival crime dynasty	Corvine Assembly	Raven-led blackmail and social-infiltration network
Secondary violent faction	Skyline Combine	Peregrine-led aerial freight and interdiction cartel
Family territory war	War over transit nodes, data vaults and laundering corridors	Territory has economic and infrastructural meaning
Police pressure	Civic Integrity Directorate	Investigation is represented through evidence chains and institutional pressure
Criminal businesses	Rackets and Accord-era monopolies	Contraband logistics, identity fabrication, illegal clinics and information brokerage
Legitimate family businesses	Public fronts	Freight, security, clubs, clinics, property and media
Family loyalty and betrayal	Motive network	Trust, grievance, ambition, secrets and external leverage
Cleanup problem	Containment or Fixer Job	Four-stage strategic operation with preparation, intervention and cover-up
Family mansion or headquarters	Meridian Atrium	Monumental diplomatic complex and dynasty command center
London neighborhoods	Five Black Meridian districts	Original districts with distinct economies and visual identities

Source structural role	Original OMNI equivalent	Material transformation
Escalating reprisals	Retaliation memory	Rival AI records humiliations, spared characters and broken agreements
Personal confrontation scenes	Walk-the-Consequence sequences	Constrained first-person splat environments tied to persistent game state

9. Art Direction

9.1 Visual thesis

Rain-lacquered interspecies noir viewed as an architectural model of organized power.

The city combines:

- monumental neo-deco towers;
- dense service alleys;
- elevated transit;
- alien diplomatic structures;
- old stone institutions;
- neon commercial layers;
- wet asphalt;
- polluted atmospheric depth;
- controlled accent colors per faction.

Avoid generic purple cyberpunk. The city should use restrained charcoal, petrol blue, oxidized metal, sodium amber and selective faction color.

9.2 Management camera

Use a perspective camera designed to read almost orthographically:

- camera angle: 35–45 degrees downward;
- equivalent focal length: approximately 55–75 mm;
- limited zoom bands;
- no unrestricted street-level camera;
- no camera rotation during the vertical slice;
- cinematic camera rails for scripted events;
- depth of field only for controlled transitions, not normal play.

The top-down camera permits:

- simplified rear façades;
- reduced underside geometry;
- lower texture resolution at street level;
- modular roof assets;

- repeated window and trim systems;
- aggressive LOD transitions hidden by rain, darkness and atmospheric perspective.

9.3 Medium allocation

Medium	Used for	Not used for
2D	UI, portraits, operation cards, district overlays, icons, faction graphics, evidence diagrams, loading illustrations	City geometry or interactive environments
Conventional 3D	Buildings, roads, traffic, crowds, hero characters, vehicles, props, animated objects, roster presentation	Full-detail interiors for every venue
Gaussian splats	Dynasty HQ interiors, crime scenes, confrontation rooms, prestige story spaces	City simulation, crowds, dynamic characters, physics or unrestricted levels

Portraits

Portraits should be 2D final images derived from approved canonical character renders. They should not be independently regenerated after a 3D character is approved unless the identity is explicitly revalidated.

Roster presentation

Each principal character receives:

- full 3D turntable;
- idle animation;
- close portrait;
- faction background;
- relationship graph;
- current status;
- visible injuries or wardrobe-state variants where narratively required.

10. Asset Production Pipeline

10.1 Route

Selected route: HYBRID

Reason:

- local generation and Blender provide repeatability and control;
- cloud tools are justified for specific production advantages;
- Godot remains local and authoritative;
- canonical character identities require local review and repair;

- Marble is used only where splat worlds provide a material visual advantage.

Primary tools

- FLUX.2 / approved image-generation workflow for canonical concepts;
- local Hunyuan3D and TripoSR for proxies and selected assets;
- Meshy Pro for targeted animated-character and hero-prop batches;
- Blender for every production mesh;
- Marble Pro for cinematic environments;
- Godot 4.7 for integration;
- Photoshop for portrait and texture repair.

Generated geometry is provisional until Blender cleanup and engine validation are complete.

10.2 Building pipeline

1. Produce district visual grammar sheet.
2. Define a modular kit:
 3. ground-floor frontage;
 4. middle floors;
 5. roof modules;
 6. corner modules;
 7. fire stairs;
 8. vents;
 9. signs;
 10. awnings;
 11. rooftop props.
12. Generate or model high-level source shapes.
13. Retopologize in Blender.
14. Standardize trim-sheet UVs.
15. Produce three LODs.
16. Add collision only where required.
17. Export GLB.
18. Validate scale, pivot, normals, materials and draw calls in Godot.
19. Generate façade variants through material, signage and prop combinations.

The full game can show 300–500 building instances without requiring 300 unique buildings.

10.3 Prop and vehicle pipeline

Use AI generation for:

- dumpsters;
- street barriers;
- kiosks;
- benches;
- market equipment;
- industrial containers;

- rooftop machinery;
- faction-specific cargo;
- non-hero vehicles.

Do not use raw generated GLBs directly.

Each asset requires:

- geometry cleanup;
- origin and pivot correction;
- real-world scale;
- material consolidation;
- UV check;
- LODs;
- collision policy;
- Godot import test.

10.4 Character pipeline

Hero characters are identity-sensitive assets.

1. Approve front, side and three-quarter canonical references.
2. Define immutable facial, body, wardrobe and species properties.
3. Generate a base mesh from multi-view references.
4. Retopologize manually or semi-automatically.
5. Rebuild face and hands as required.
6. Create a shared humanoid skeleton where anatomy permits.
7. Use species-specific skeleton extensions only where necessary.
8. Create a controlled animation set:
 9. idle;
 10. inspect;
 11. speak;
 12. threaten;
 13. sit;
 14. walk;
 15. turn;
 16. gesture;
 17. injured;
 18. roster pose.
 19. Validate facial identity under roster and cinematic lighting.
 20. Promote to canonical only after explicit approval.

Do not attempt seven unique bespoke animation rigs during the vertical slice.

11. Asset Scale Targets

Vertical slice

- 1 district;
- 8 city blocks;
- 12 modular building kits;
- approximately 40 visible building instances;
- 50–70 reusable props;
- 8 vehicle models with material variants;
- 6 pedestrian archetypes;
- 4 hero-grade character models;
- 1 Gaussian-splat environment;
- 1 collider mesh for that environment;
- 1 visual-effects package for rain, steam, signage and road reflections.

Full game

- 5 districts;
- 50–60 modular building components;
- 300–500 building instances;
- 180–250 reusable props;
- 24–30 vehicle models;
- 18–24 crowd archetypes;
- 7 hero-grade characters;
- 15–20 secondary character models built from controlled bases;
- 10–12 splat environments.

These numbers are content ceilings, not promises to exceed.

12. Scope Discipline

12.1 Vertical slice

Location

One district: **Glass Wharf**

A wet freight and nightlife district built around a vertical cargo terminal.

Playable content

- one complete Night Cycle;
- 45–60 minutes;
- ruling Compact versus Corvine Assembly;
- four rackets;
- two fronts;
- eight fixer jobs;
- three authored;

- five systemic;
- one evidence chain;
- one loyalty crisis;
- one district-control escalation;
- one first-person splat sequence;
- one significant ending decision;
- replayable through at least two strategic approaches.

Required characters

- Aiko;
- Regent;
- Bengal lieutenant;
- Raven rival.

Required systems

- pause and speed control;
- district and venue state;
- dirty and clean economy;
- local heat;
- one evidence chain;
- rival utility AI;
- fixer-job lifecycle;
- relationship state;
- save/load;
- cinematic transition;
- one complete UI theme;
- settings and performance controls.

12.2 Full-game target

- five districts;
- three active rival dynasties;
- one neutral institution network;
- all seven OMNI characters;
- 35–45 fixer jobs;
- 60–80 systemic crisis templates;
- 10–12 splat sequences;
- three campaign endings;
- 12–15 hour initial campaign;
- replayability through faction alliances, character outcomes and economic strategies.

12.3 Explicit cuts

The following are outside scope:

- direct character combat;
- tactical combat maps;
- drivable vehicles;
- open-world street exploration;

- entering arbitrary buildings;
- city construction or road placement;
- individual citizen schedules;
- destructible city environments;
- multiplayer;
- co-op;
- procedural dialogue generation at runtime;
- runtime AI image or mesh generation;
- seven fully independent character rigs;
- fully voiced 15-hour branching screenplay for version 1.0;
- separate Unity executable for cinematic scenes;
- Steam Workshop at initial release;
- console ports before the PC game is commercially validated;
- more than one splat sequence in the vertical slice.

The first six months produce a Steam-quality vertical slice, not the full commercial game.

13. Technical Architecture

13.1 Engine decision: Godot 4.7

Godot 4.7 became the stable release on June 18, 2026. Godot has first-class glTF/GLB support and the existing OMNI stack already defines Godot 4.7, Blender-to-Godot validation and Godot MCP workflows as studio capabilities.

Why Godot wins for this project

- Existing tooling and operating knowledge.
- Fast iteration for data-driven strategy systems.
- No engine subscription requirement.
- Source access and controllable build pipeline.
- Strong scene composition and UI model.
- GLB-centered Blender workflow.
- The core game does not require Unity-specific physics, multiplayer or console middleware.
- Switching engines would consume the advantage provided by AI-assisted production.

Where Unity is stronger

- Larger commercial asset and middleware ecosystem.
- More mature cinematic and profiling tooling.
- World Labs publishes a direct Unity splat-integration guide.
- Meshy and many AI vendors prioritize Unity integrations.

Unity Personal remains free below its current \$200,000 revenue/funding threshold; Unity Pro is currently listed at \$2,310 per seat annually for 2026. The former runtime fee has been cancelled.

Why that does not justify switching

The game is primarily:

- UI;
- simulation logic;
- data;
- controlled 3D presentation;
- GLB assets;
- scripted cinematic scenes.

Unity's ecosystem advantage does not outweigh six months of pipeline replacement and new tooling risk.

Decision

Use **Godot 4.7 Forward+**.

Do not reconsider Unity unless the Gaussian-splat technical spike fails and splat-native first-person sequences remain non-negotiable after testing the mesh fallback.

13.2 Simulation architecture

Use a deterministic strategic simulation separated from presentation.

Core services

```
GameState
TimeService
DistrictService
EconomyService
HeatService
EvidenceService
RelationshipService
JobDirector
RivalDirector
NarrativeDirector
SaveService
PresentationBridge
```

Tick model

- visual frame: normal render rate;
- strategic tick: 1 second;
- economic settlement: phase boundary;
- rival decision tick: approximately 10 seconds;
- narrative condition evaluation: after material state changes.

Avoid placing core simulation state directly inside city-scene nodes.

13.3 Data ownership

Use typed Godot Resources or validated JSON for:

- characters;
- factions;
- districts;
- venues;
- rackets;
- fronts;
- jobs;
- evidence chains;
- relationship modifiers;
- narrative conditions.

Every authored operation should be data-driven rather than hard-coded into UI scenes.

13.4 Suggested repository structure

```
/game
  /addons
    /gdgs
  /assets
    /characters
    /city
    /vehicles
    /props
    /splat
    /ui
    /audio
  /data
    /characters
    /districts
    /factions
    /jobs
    /narrative
  /scenes
    /bootstrap
    /city
    /cinematic
    /ui
  /src
    /core
    /simulation
    /ai
    /jobs
    /narrative
    /presentation
    /save
  /tests
```

```
/unit
/integration
/smoke
/tools
/import
/validation
project.godot
```

14. Marble-to-Godot Integration

14.1 Current technical facts

Marble can export:

- approximately 2 million or 500,000-splat SPZ files;
- approximately 2 million or 500,000-splat PLY files;
- a coarse collider GLB of roughly 100,000–200,000 triangles;
- high-quality GLBs around 600,000 to 1 million triangles.

Godot does not currently provide built-in Gaussian-splat support. The community GDGS 2.2.0 plugin supports Godot 4.4 or newer, Forward+, desktop compute-capable GPUs, PLY-family assets, hybrid rendering with normal Godot geometry and depth-aware composition. Its published limitations include no mobile renderer and possible 4K GPU-memory pressure.

This is sufficient for a technical spike, not sufficient to claim production compatibility without testing.

14.2 Production integration

For each cinematic world:

Marble world	
├ 500k PLY	minimum-quality splat
├ 2M PLY	high-quality splat
├ collider.glb	physics and walkable boundaries
├ anchors.json	interactions, character marks and camera limits
└ preview.mp4	fallback and QA reference

Runtime sequence

1. Pause strategic simulation.
2. Save a transition checkpoint.
3. Unload or hide the city scene.
4. Load one isolated `CinematicWorld`.
5. Load the selected PLY through GDGS.
6. Load the collider GLB through the standard GLB pipeline.
7. Instantiate normal 3D characters and interactive props.
8. Apply a scene-specific LUT and character lighting.

9. Limit the player to the validated camera volume.
10. Resolve interactions.
11. write narrative consequences;
12. unload the splat world;
13. restore the city and resume simulation.

Visual restrictions

- Splats contain baked illumination; they do not respond like conventional materials.
- Dynamic lights should illuminate characters and props, not be expected to relight the environment.
- No large moving doors or destruction should be baked into the splat.
- Camera movement must remain inside the region validated during export.
- Only one splat environment should be resident at a time.
- 500k and 2M modes should be exposed as performance settings.

Coordinate handling

Export Marble assets in OpenGL coordinates and standardize scale and origin in Blender before Godot integration. Marble added OpenGL/OpenCV export selection and improved grounding and real-world scale handling in its 2026 updates.

14.3 Fallback strategy

Create a provider interface:

```
CinematicWorldProvider
├─ SplatWorldProvider
└─ MeshWorldProvider
```

If splat rendering fails performance or compatibility gates:

- use Marble's high-quality GLB as the environment;
- use the collider GLB as the simplified physics layer;
- preserve the same interaction, narrative and camera data;
- add baked lighting, fog cards and limited 360 projections to recover visual density.

Do not migrate the entire project to Unity solely to preserve one cinematic technique.

World Labs' own Unity documentation currently relies on community plugins and records draw-order, SPZ-import and version-specific issues, so Unity would not remove integration risk; it would merely move it.

15. Performance Strategy

Working targets

- 60 fps at 1080p High on the recommended target;
- 45–60 fps in a 2M-splat cinematic scene;

- 60 fps in the city view;
- no ray tracing requirement;
- one-click 500k-splat fallback;
- no city and splat world resident simultaneously.

City optimization

- MultiMesh for repeated props and crowds;
- spline traffic instead of vehicle physics;
- pooled pedestrian agents;
- distance-based animation update rates;
- occlusion culling;
- three building LOD levels;
- trim sheets and texture atlases;
- material consolidation;
- fixed camera bands;
- district streaming only if profiling proves it necessary.

Crowd illusion

Do not simulate hundreds of autonomous agents.

Use:

- 20–40 near pedestrians with simple navigation;
- 100–200 distant MultiMesh crowd instances;
- looping crosswalk and platform groups;
- district-state-driven spawn density;
- audio beds to imply population beyond the rendered area.

16. AI Subscription Decision

Prices and terms below are current as of July 1, 2026 and must be rechecked before purchase.

Buy: Marble Pro — \$35/month, only during cinematic production

Marble Pro includes approximately 25 world generations, high-quality textured-mesh export and commercial rights to generated worlds. Standard provides exports but Pro is the entry point explicitly listing commercial rights.

Use it for

- the vertical-slice crime scene;
- dynasty HQ;
- later confrontation environments;
- collider and high-quality mesh fallbacks.

Subscription timing

- Do not maintain it for all six months.

- Use free testing for initial quality evaluation.
- Activate Pro when producing final commercial cinematic assets.
- Expect one or two paid production months for the slice.
- Do not buy Max.

Buy selectively: Meshy Pro — \$20/month for one production burst

Meshy Pro currently includes 1,000 monthly credits, private asset ownership and API access. Its official Godot bridge requires Pro or above and supports animated-model transfer with animation data preserved.

Use it for

- initial Aiko body base;
- Bengal and Raven character bases;
- hero props;
- testing auto-rigged secondary characters;
- quickly transferring animation tests into Godot.

Restriction

Meshy output is not a canonical or game-ready character. It remains input to Blender reconstruction, retopology, rig validation and identity repair.

Subscription timing

One paid month during character-production batching. Renew only if the approved-asset yield justifies it.

Do not buy initially: Tripo Pro

Tripo Pro is competitively priced at \$19.90 monthly, with 3,000 credits, up to 120 models, multi-view generation, bulk export, private models and commercial use.

It is not the initial recommendation because:

- local Hunyuan3D and TripoSR already cover rapid geometry and proxy generation;
- the city should use modular kits rather than hundreds of unrelated generated models;
- Meshy's current Godot bridge and animated-model workflow address a more expensive production bottleneck;
- paying for Meshy and Tripo simultaneously creates duplicated capability.

Activation condition

Replace Meshy with one month of Tripo Pro only if a controlled benchmark shows that Tripo produces materially better building and vehicle geometry per hour after Blender cleanup.

Do not subscribe to both by default.

Recommended external spend for the six-month slice

Marble Pro: 1–2 months	\$35–70
Meshy Pro: 1 month	\$20
Tripo Pro:	\$0 initially
Total targeted spend:	\$55–90

This excludes optional extra credits and taxes.

17. Monetization

17.1 Base product

Recommended launch price: \$29.99

Rationale:

- high enough to communicate premium strategy positioning;
- inside the requested \$25–35 range;
- leaves room for launch and seasonal discounts;
- requires a complete campaign, not an experiment sold on visual novelty.

Do not launch the vertical slice as the finished game.

17.2 Launch model

- complete premium game;
- no microtransactions;
- no premium currency;
- no always-online requirement;
- no content chopped from the base game to manufacture a season pass;
- optional soundtrack and digital art book.

A 10% launch discount is reasonable, but the final discount and regional pricing should be set using the then-current Steamworks tools.

17.3 DLC strategy

Do not announce a multi-year season before validating sales.

Expansion format

One substantial expansion should contain:

- one new district;
- one new dynasty;
- one principal OMNI character;
- eight to twelve fixer jobs;

- two or three splat sequences;
- approximately three to four hours of campaign content;
- new systemic events usable in the base campaign.

Target price: **\$9.99–12.99**.

Smaller content

Only after a stable base game:

- soundtrack;
- art book;
- optional scenario pack;
- free balance and event updates.

Avoid selling isolated character skins. The character roster should feel like narrative content, not collectible cosmetics.

17.4 Long-tail strategy

The game continues selling through:

- multiple faction outcomes;
- deterministic but partially hidden betrayal states;
- alternate alliances;
- systemic fixer jobs;
- several campaign endings;
- periodic free event additions;
- one meaningful expansion;
- strong screenshots and cinematic trailers that remain visually competitive.

Do not build live-service infrastructure.

17.5 Refund-risk mitigation

Steam's normal refund policy covers games requested within 14 days and played for less than two hours.

Design the opening accordingly:

- first strategic decision within three minutes;
- first operation within eight minutes;
- first visible rival response within fifteen minutes;
- first loyalty consequence within thirty minutes;
- first premium transition or cinematic sequence within sixty minutes;
- no 90-minute exposition prologue;
- no misleading pre-rendered trailer;
- expose actual management gameplay in the first store trailer;
- provide a 30–45 minute public demo;
- include clear performance settings;
- allow cutscene skipping and dialogue acceleration;

- support autosave and manual save;
- never hide the fact that first-person sections are constrained narrative sequences.

The best refund mitigation is expectation accuracy, not stretching content beyond two hours.

18. Vertical-Slice Acceptance Criteria

The slice is acceptable only when all conditions are met.

Gameplay

- A complete Night Cycle is playable.
- The player can pursue at least two viable strategies.
- Rival AI responds to district and character state.
- One betrayal or loyalty crisis is causally understandable.
- Economy, heat and evidence interact rather than acting as independent meters.
- At least six of eight fixer jobs can be completed without scripting errors.

Presentation

- The city reads as active without menu overlays.
- Rain, traffic, crowds and faction activity respond to district state.
- Four character identities remain stable across portrait, roster and cinematic use.
- The transition into and out of the splat sequence is visually coherent.
- UI is readable at 1080p and 1440p.

Technical

- Save/load survives all major state transitions.
- Deterministic systems have unit tests.
- A complete Night Cycle passes an automated smoke test.
- No missing GLB dependencies.
- No critical material or skeleton errors.
- City performance meets the working target.
- The splat scene meets the fallback threshold or switches to the mesh provider.
- A clean Windows build launches without the editor installed.

Commercial

- Store description accurately matches the slice.
 - Trailer includes real strategic gameplay.
 - All generated and purchased asset licenses are recorded.
 - Character and title similarity review is completed.
 - Crash reporting and version display are present.
 - Known limitations are documented.
-

19. Six-Month Roadmap

Month 1 — Architecture and Risk Spikes

Deliverables

- approved project brief;
- working title and original-world bible;
- Aiko role decision;
- greybox Glass Wharf;
- management camera;
- district and venue data model;
- strategic tick;
- one dirty-income loop;
- one placeholder fixer job;
- one sample Marble PLY and collider GLB loaded in Godot;
- GDGS benchmark;
- basic save/load.

Gate

A 15-minute greybox loop must be playable.

Kill criterion

If 500k splats cannot run acceptably on the target desktop class, activate the mesh provider immediately. Do not postpone the decision.

Month 2 — Complete Core Loop

Deliverables

- rackets;
- fronts;
- laundering;
- heat;
- evidence-chain prototype;
- one rival utility AI;
- operation assignment;
- job preparation and resolution;
- pause and speed controls;
- district-state visual hooks;
- first-pass UI;
- unit tests for economy and rival scoring.

Gate

A complete 25–30 minute Night Cycle must be fun with cubes and placeholder art.

If it is not compelling without final visuals, do not enter asset production.

Month 3 — Art Pipeline and Character Proof

Deliverables

- Glass Wharf art-direction master;
- modular building kit;
- road and roof kit;
- rain and wet-surface package;
- traffic and crowd proxy system;
- approved Aiko canonical references;
- four character base models;
- shared animation prototype;
- roster screen;
- GLB import validation scripts;
- final asset naming and folder structure.

Gate

The team must prove repeatable delivery of:

- one cleaned modular building component;
- one cleaned prop;
- one cleaned vehicle;
- one character animation update;

without manual pipeline reinvention each time.

Month 4 — Narrative and Cinematic Integration

Deliverables

- three authored fixer jobs;
- five systemic job templates;
- complete evidence chain;
- first loyalty crisis;
- final Marble cinematic world;
- collider mesh;
- interaction anchors;
- Aiko first-person controller;
- two-character confrontation;
- transition back to the strategic state;
- audio and dialogue implementation.

Gate

The splat sequence must change persistent strategic state and survive save/load before and after entry.

A visually attractive but non-persistent scene does not pass.

Month 5 — Content Completion and Polish

Deliverables

- complete vertical-slice narrative;
- final rival behavior;
- city-state visual variations;
- four final character presentations;
- onboarding;
- settings;
- rebinding;
- subtitle and text-size support;
- performance tiers;
- 500k/2M splat selection;
- mesh fallback;
- sound mix;
- first trailer capture.

Gate

Three external players must complete the slice without developer instruction and correctly explain:

- how money is cleaned;
 - why heat increased;
 - why the rival acted;
 - why the loyalty crisis occurred.
-

Month 6 — Steam-Quality Vertical Slice

Deliverables

- 45–60 minute polished build;
- Windows export;
- installer/build packaging;
- crash and log collection;
- complete smoke-test suite;
- regression checklist;
- Steam store assets;
- honest gameplay trailer;
- public-demo configuration;
- license and provenance manifest;
- performance report;
- QA report;
- known-limitations record;
- final vertical-slice delivery package.

Gate

No critical defects.

The build must launch, save, load, complete a Night Cycle, enter and exit the cinematic scene, and reach the ending on a clean machine.

20. Decisions Requiring Approval

These decisions materially change design or production cost.

1. Aiko's authority:

Current assumption: Aiko is the playable fixer serving the Regent, not the dynasty ruler.

Should the player remain a constrained operator, or eventually overthrow and replace the Regent?

2. World relationship to Earth:

Current assumption: Black Meridian is a fully original interspecies city with no London or alternate-Earth connection.

Should the setting remain entirely fictional, or exist in a future Earth where humans and OMNI species coexist?

3. Cinematic fallback:

Current assumption: Gaussian-splat exploration is preferred, but a high-quality Marble mesh is an acceptable technical fallback.

Is true Gaussian-splat rendering mandatory for the commercial identity even if it narrows hardware support?

4. Campaign structure:

Current assumption: a directed 12–15 hour campaign with systemic variation.

Should the final game prioritize a stronger authored ending, or an endless empire sandbox after the campaign?

5. Permanent character roles:

Current assignments use species labels as placeholders.

Canonical names, faction identities, immutable visual properties and relationship histories must be approved before hero-character production.